

The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

A data-driven overview of global mental health conditions, disease burden, and gaps in care — global data, 2023.

For public health policy analysts and mental health program planners

Hundreds of Millions Affected: Major Depression Risk Is Substantial

Lifetime major depression risk

1 in 3

women

will experience major depression in their
lifetime

1 in 5

men

will experience major depression in their
lifetime

**Mental health conditions
span a wide spectrum:**

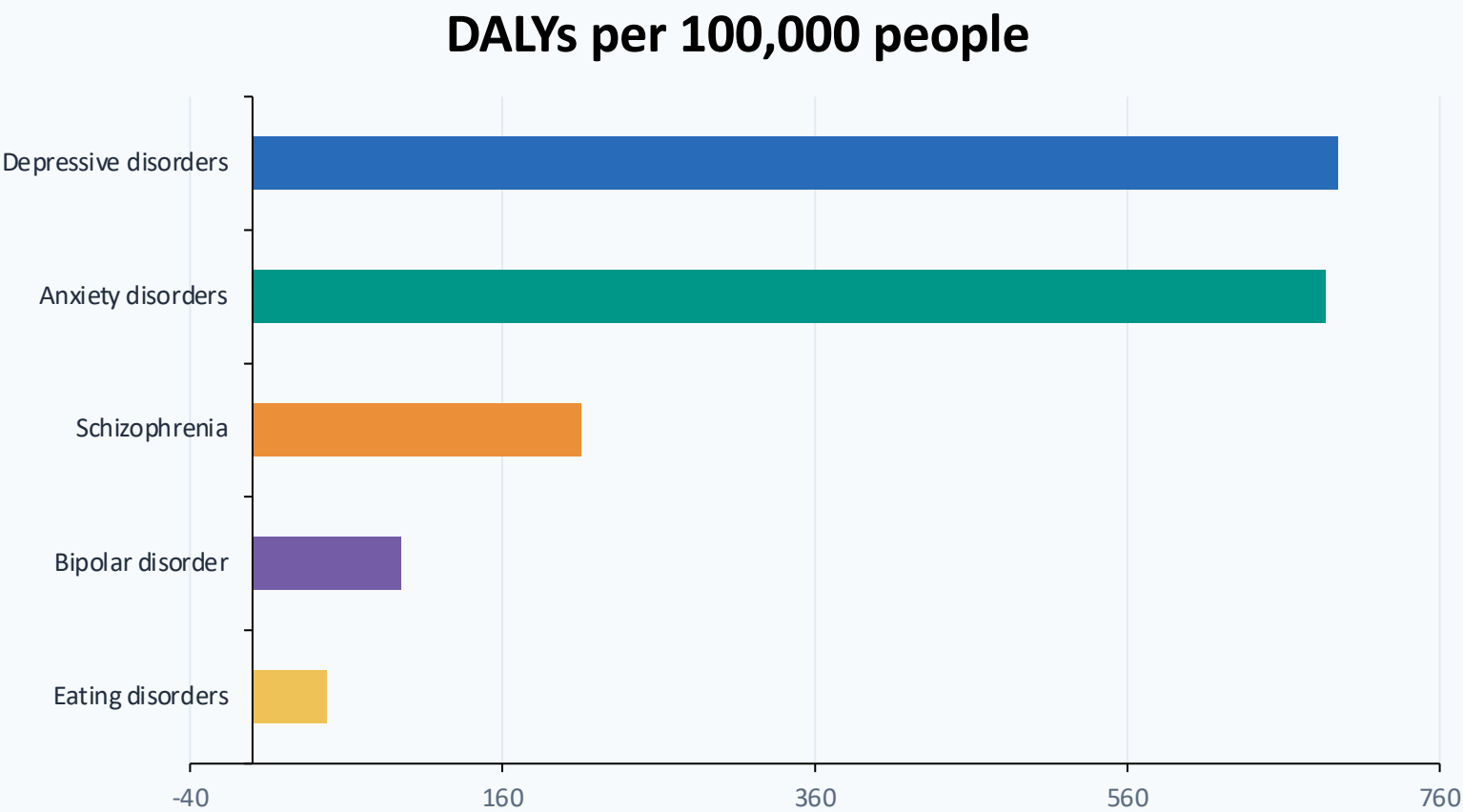
Common: depression and
anxiety

Less common but severe:
schizophrenia and bipolar
disorder

Policy relevance: scale
interventions for common
conditions while maintaining
specialized capacity for severe
illness.

Mental health affects well-being, ability to work, and relationships with friends, family, and community.

Depression and Anxiety Dominate Mental Health DALYs



DALYs combine years of life lost and years lived with disability.

Depressive and anxiety disorders each generate about 690 DALYs per 100,000 people — nearly equal in magnitude.

Together they account for roughly 80% of the total burden across these five categories.

Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Disease Burden Worldwide

Depressive disorders



Anxiety disorders



DALYs per 100,000 people

**Only 8.1 DALYs
apart**

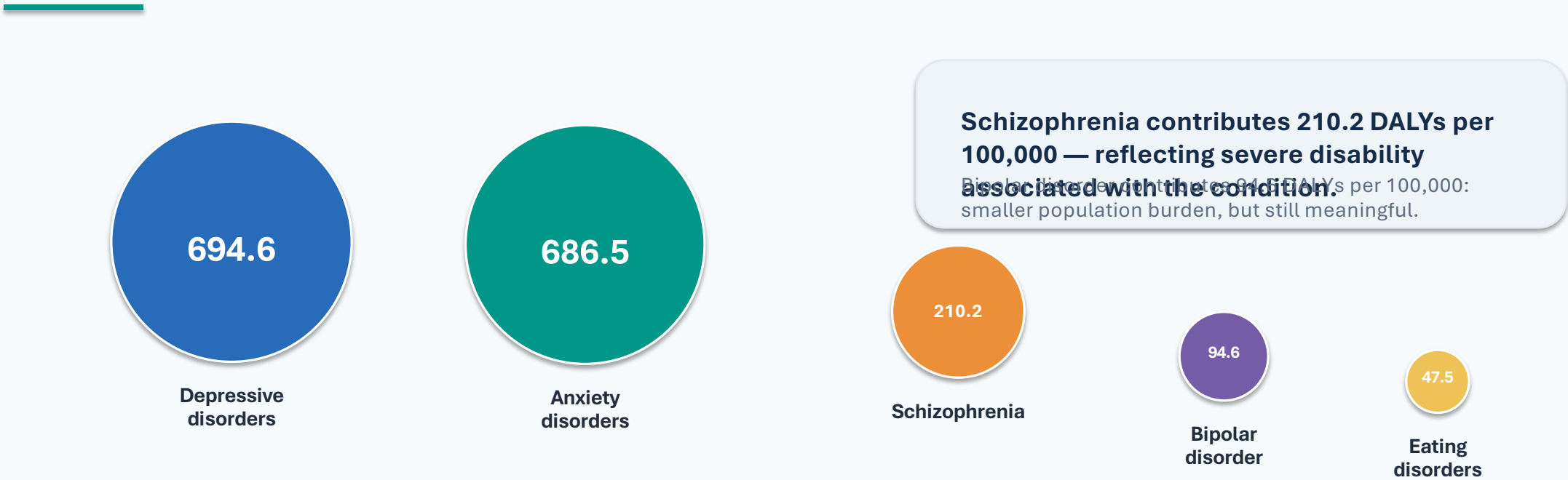
Depressive disorders: 694.6

Anxiety disorders: 686.5

The policy signal is parity: planning should treat both as high-burden priorities, not as separate tiers of importance.

Combined, depression and anxiety represent roughly 80% of the total burden across the five listed categories.

Schizophrenia and Bipolar Disorder: Lower Prevalence, Severe Individual Impact



DALYs per 100,000 people, scaled by circle area

Planning implication: lower population prevalence does not eliminate the need for specialized care pathways.

Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking or Poor Quality



A large treatment gap means reported burden may understate actual need.

How People Cope: From Medication to Faith to Family Conversations



Prescribed medication

common in higher-income settings



Religious or spiritual activities

prevalent in many regions worldwide



Talking to friends or family

a widely reported coping mechanism

Survey findings show coping strategies vary widely across countries and cultures; policy responses should be culturally sensitive rather than one-size-fits-all.

Key Takeaways

Prioritizing depression, anxiety, and closing the treatment gap

- 1 Depression and anxiety represent the overwhelming majority of DALYs across the five listed categories.
- 2 Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder carry disproportionate individual burden and require specialized care.
- 3 Treatment exists, but access and quality remain inadequate in many settings.
- 4 Stigma suppresses help-seeking and accurate data through underreporting.
- 5 Policy should scale evidence-based interventions for common disorders while maintaining care for severe conditions.